Humayun had just assumed his father's throne; one day, he would need a successor in turn.[53]

Maham Begum died well before Humayun lost his inheritance; she was spared the humiliation of his collapse. Might she have endured it all for the chance to exult in this longed-for moment; or would it have increased her dismay, to have an heir born, finally, but with nothing to inherit?

Perhaps not. Kings, like artists, must live on hope. As Akbar was born, in fact, Humayun had a vision of a magical new dawn. The padishah was absorbed in meditation, sitting in a trance, when he called out, 'Praise be to God . . . the lamp of our royal family has been relit.'

A chieftain who stood nearby – and later narrated the whole story to Abul Fazl – asked what Humayun had seen. It was, said his emperor, as if a bright star had risen over Umarkot, and 'as it ascended, its size and brilliance increased, until its light had embraced the greater portion of the world'.

What could it be, this light?

'It was the light incarnate of my successor,' came the reply.

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Regardless of visions and marvels, Akbar's very birth – that Hamida and her unborn child had survived their trials under the desert sun – was something of a miracle. His continued survival, moreover, was uncertain. Akbar was born a refugee; his parents impoverished, beset by enemies on the one hand, seeking kindness from strangers on the other. Given these circumstances, the celebrations at Akbar's birth may not have been as extravagant as Abul Fazl claims ('there is no need of explanation or description', he writes demurely, after a page-full of 'Dark-haired maidens . . . Rose-cheeked damsels . . . Red-garmented, sweetly-smiling nymphs . . . scattering saffron' as musicians create 'enchanting ecstasy') – but they would have been heartfelt.

Jouher's account of Humayun's reaction to the news is more credible. Humayun and his faithful water carrier were camped by a pond not far from Umarkot when they saw a rider galloping towards them. By one account, this was Tardi Beg; and Humayun showed his pleasure by forgiving the Chagatai[54] Scrooge his many sins.[55] Then he summoned Jouher to bring out